INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #2 · PARENTS

"I can never please my parents."

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Where it often comes from

Some parents set standards that keep moving. A good grade is met with "why not an A-plus," a success is met with silence, and a mistake is remembered for years. Children of such homes often grow into adults who work hard to earn approval that never comes, and who feel on edge around their parents even decades later.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asks, "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ." The psalmist says, "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made." Scripture does call us to honor our father and mother, but honor is not the same as winning their approval. Honor can mean respect, kindness, and care, offered without needing their applause. The Bible also tells fathers not to provoke their children to wrath, which means that impossible standards are a parent's failing, not a child's.

> *"Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ"* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "Honor your father and mother, so that your days may be long in the land that the LORD your God is giving you" (Exodus 20:12).

> "Fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath; instead, bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord" (Ephesians 6:4).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- Nothing I do is ever enough.
- They will always find something wrong.
- I am a disappointment to them.
- If I try harder, maybe they will finally approve.
- I dread seeing them.
- I cannot relax around them.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming I know in advance how they will react.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should be able to win their approval.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either pleasing them or failing.
- Personalization: Treating their dissatisfaction as proof of my failure.

Challenging questions

- When did I first notice that nothing was ever enough?

- Is it possible that their dissatisfaction says more about them than about me?
- What would pleasing them completely look like, and has it ever been possible?
- What is the difference between honoring my parents and needing their approval?
- What does God say about me?
- What would change if I stopped trying to earn their applause?

Truth summary

> I can honor my parents without needing to win their approval. Their standards are not the measure of my worth. God accepts me in Christ, and I can live to please Him and serve people with a free heart.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Obedience
- Pride
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting
- Commandments

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I can never please my parents"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I can never please my parents." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did nothing become enough?
- ☐ What did they expect?
- ☐ What does honor look like without approval?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ What will I say when criticized?
- ☐ What would freedom feel like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth is not their approval.
- ☐ I can honor my parents without earning their praise.
- ☐ Impossible standards are not my fault.
- ☐ God accepts me in Christ.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I am free to live to please God.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Psalm 139:14**
  "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well."
- ☐ **Ephesians 6:4**
  "Fathers, do not provoke your children to wrath; instead, bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Approval or honor?: Each week, note one time you honored a parent without seeking approval.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 1:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can honor my parents and still live to please God.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the standard. Write what your parents expected and whether anyone could have met it.
- [ ] Practice honor without performance. Do one kind thing for a parent without hoping for praise.
- [ ] Plan for the visit. Before contact, decide in advance how you will respond calmly to criticism.
- [ ] Memorize Galatians 1:10. Say it before a difficult conversation.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I can never please my parents": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Honor without performance
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I can never please my parents.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have worn myself out trying to please people who are never satisfied. Teach me to honor my parents and to rest in Your approval. Free me from the need to earn what You have already given. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.